

BRIDGEPULSE · DESIGN PRECIS

BridgePulse design precis

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DOCUMENT CONTROL

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Author	Amish Chadha	License	CERN-OHL-S-2.0
Project TRL	TRL 3 Proof of concept		
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REVISION HISTORY

Version	Date	Author	Change
0.3	2026-09-25	Amish Chadha	TRL 3 update; design choices adopted for TRL 3 per BRP-DDR-001; numbers from BRP-CAL-001; jacked mounting plate, switched-rail power, curve-fit frequency estimate, mass-loading finding
0.2	2026-09-25	Amish Chadha	Concept for TRL 2; architecture, first-order numbers, safety and open questions
0.1	2026-09-25	Amish Chadha	Initial scaffold

BridgePulse design precis

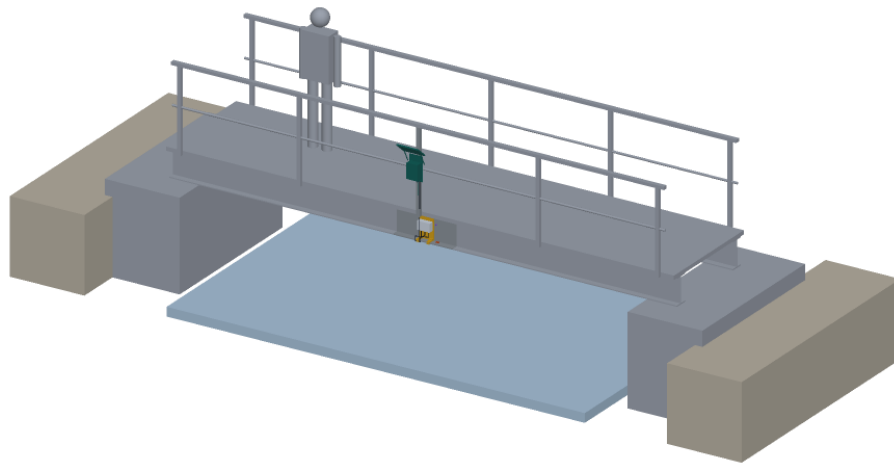
■ Summary

BridgePulse is a clamp-on monitor for small bridges and footbridges. A sensor hub fixed to a girder at midspan records ambient vibration, strain and temperature for 10 minutes every hour, works out the bridge's natural frequencies and strain statistics on board, and sends a short summary through a FieldNode core over LoRaWAN to TwinKit or CityTwin. Over weeks the system learns how the frequencies move with temperature; a sustained shift outside that band is flagged to the bridge owner's engineer as a reason to inspect sooner. It is a research prototype that supports inspection, never a safety rating.

The TRL 3 calculations (BRP-CAL-001) give 16.9 mW average draw at the FieldNode port, a 36-byte hourly uplink, 1.39 GB per month of raw records kept on a microSD card (22 months on 32 GB), and \$244 of BridgePulse-specific parts (\$370 with the FieldNode core). On the 7 m example footbridge the first mode is 23.9 Hz and the instrument can track it to 0.05 % an hour, but walkers' own mass lowers it by up to 6 % while they cross; this is the main open problem (R2 not met, R3 not verifiable at TRL 3).

BridgePulse

CONCEPT, NOT FOR FABRICATION



Grey: Example 7 m steel footbridge, banks, stream, 1.75 m person for scale

Figure 1. Concept render. The monitor clusters at midspan: sensor hub between the flanges of the south girder, FieldNode core on the handrail post. Grey parts are the existing bridge and a 1.75 m person for scale.

■ How it works

1. **Sense.** A low-noise 3-axis MEMS accelerometer, fixed inside the hub to the enclosure base, picks up the bridge's response to wind, footfall and traffic. The hub sits on an aluminium plate that stands on the bottom flange against the web and is wedged against the top flange by a jack screw, so that its own mounting resonance (126 to 253 Hz) is well above the measured band. Two strain gauge half-bridges under the bottom flanges of both girders at midspan measure bending strain. Two temperature probes measure the steel and the shaded air under the deck.
2. **Record.** Once an hour the FieldNode core switches on the 5 V rail of its sensor port. The hub boots, warms the gauges for 20 s and samples for 600 s: acceleration at 250 Hz on three axes, strain at 20 Hz on two channels, temperature once a minute. The raw record goes to an industrial microSD card so an engineer can download it later.
3. **Reduce.** The hub reads the record back from the card one axis at a time, computes averaged spectra (Welch method, 65.5 s Hann segments with 50 % overlap), and estimates the frequencies of the first modes below 60 Hz by fitting a single-degree-of-freedom spectrum around each peak. It also computes peak amplitudes, RMS acceleration, and the strain minimum, maximum and mean on each channel.
4. **Send.** The 36-byte summary passes over RS-485 on the M12 cable to the FieldNode core, which sends it as one LoRaWAN uplink; the rail is then switched off until the next hour. At the slowest US915 and AS923 data rates a reduced 11-byte summary is proposed (BRP-CAL-001, G).
5. **Learn and flag.** TwinKit stores the series and fits frequency against steel temperature over a baseline period, following the approach of the Z24 bridge study (Peeters and De Roeck, 2001). A frequency that stays outside the confidence band for a set period, or a step in the strain baseline, raises a flag to the owner's engineer. On light footbridges the model must also account for the load on the deck (see Key numbers). TwinKit can show the measured frequency next to the value calculated from the bridge model.
6. **Act.** The engineer decides whether to inspect. The public CityTwin view shows only that the bridge is monitored and when data last arrived.

BridgePulse: hourly data flow (estimates)

CONCEPT, NOT FOR FABRICATION

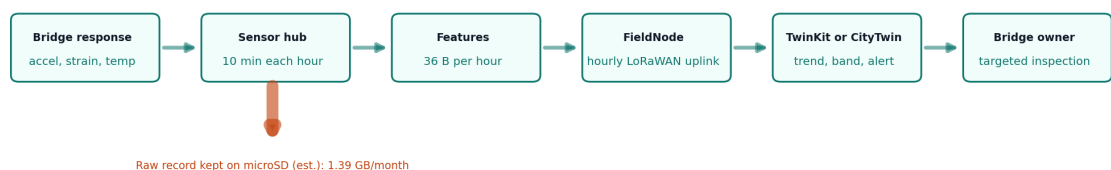


Figure 2. Hourly data flow. Values are estimates from BRP-CAL-001.

■ Main components

Numbers match the exploded view (Figure 3) and `bom/bom.csv`. The general arrangement is drawing BRP-DWG-001.

No.	Component	Role
1	Sensor hub enclosure, die-cast aluminium, IP67, 170 × 64 × 110 mm	Stiff, sealed housing that couples the accelerometer to the plate; two M12 glands and an M12 panel connector underneath
2	Accelerometer board, ADXL355 class	3-axis, 22.5 µg/√Hz noise density, 200 µA in measurement mode (Analog Devices)
3	Signal board: 24-bit bridge ADC (ADS1220 class), RP2040 class microcontroller, 5 V to 3.3 V buck converter, RS-485 transceiver, microSD socket, gauge excitation switch	Sampling, spectra, features, raw storage, link to FieldNode
4	Mounting plate, 200 × 313 × 8 mm 6061 aluminium, with an M12 jack screw to the top flange and two flange-tip clamps	Holds the hub between the flanges, inside the girder outline; no drilling
5	Strain gauge half-bridges (2): each an active 350 Ω foil gauge on the flange plus a dummy gauge on an unstrained coupon of the same steel, with protective coating and cover	Bending strain at midspan of each girder, temperature-compensated
6	Temperature probes (2), sealed DS18B20 class	Steel and shaded air temperature for frequency compensation
7	Sensor cables and M12 connectors	Gauges to hub, hub to FieldNode
8	FieldNode core: IP65 enclosure, 6 W panel as sun hood, LiFePO4 cell, MPPT charger, LoRaWAN radio, pole clamps	Power, radio and mounting shared across the lab's outdoor projects
9	microSD card, industrial grade, 32 GB	Raw records on site (in item 3; not shown separately)

BridgePulse: exploded view

CONCEPT, NOT FOR FABRICATION

- 1 Sensor hub enclosure, IP67 die-cast
- 2 Accelerometer board, ADXL355
- 3 Signal board: 24-bit ADC, MCU, microSD, RS-485
- 4 Mounting plate, jack screw and flange clamps
- 5 Strain gauge half-bridges (2)
- 6 Temperature probes (2)
- 7 Sensor cables and M12 connectors
- 8 FieldNode core (6 W panel, cell, radio)

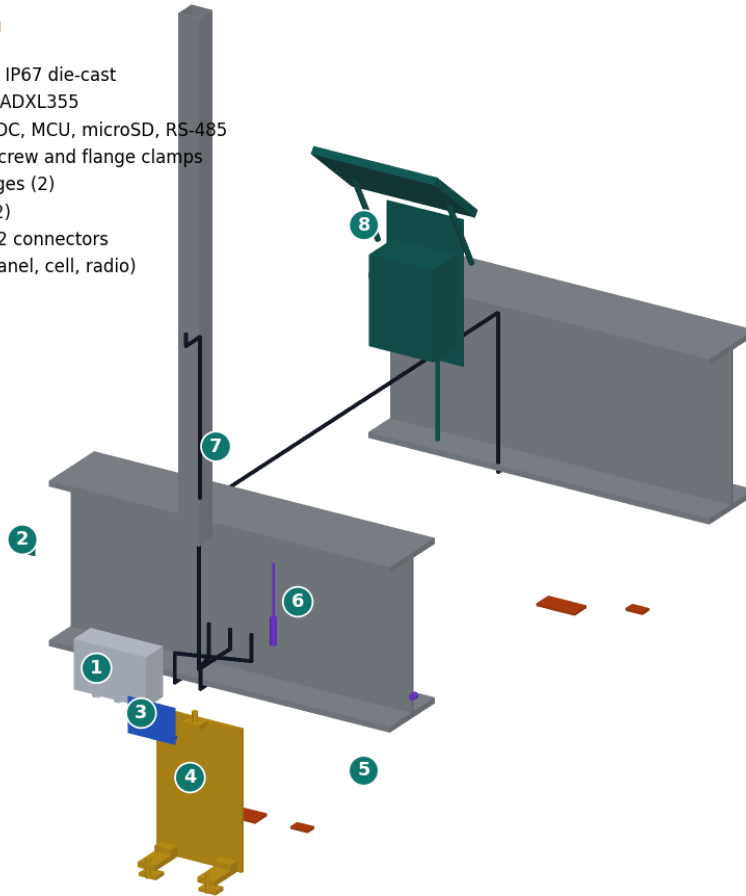


Figure 3. Exploded view with BOM numbers. The girder and post are existing structure.

BridgePulse: sensor hub cutaway

CONCEPT, NOT FOR FABRICATION

- 1 Sensor hub enclosure, IP67 die-cast
- 2 Accelerometer board, ADXL355
- 3 Signal board: 24-bit ADC, MCU, microSD, RS-485
- 4 Mounting plate, jack screw and flange clamps

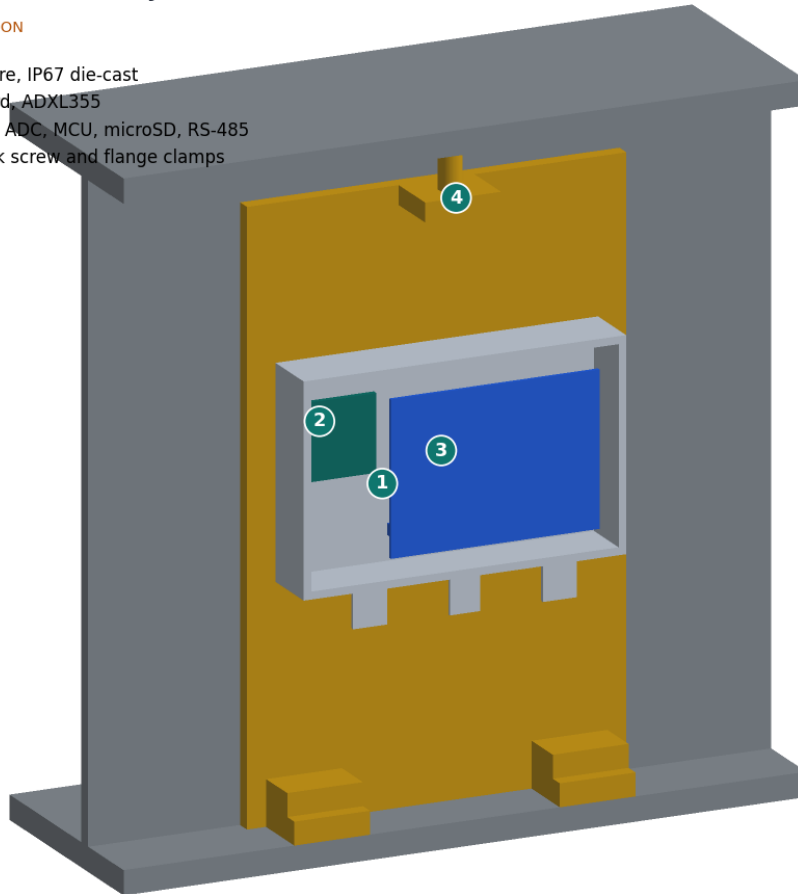


Figure 4. Cutaway of the sensor hub on its plate, between the flanges of the south girder. The accelerometer board is fixed to the base of the enclosure on the plate side so it moves with the girder.

■ Key numbers (BRP-CAL-001)

All values come from BRP-CAL-001 v0.1, which states its assumptions; they are calculations, not measurements.

Example bridge

- 6.4 m between bearings; two IPE 360 class girders; $EI = 6.52 \times 10^7 \text{ N}\cdot\text{m}^2$; 167 kg/m. First vertical mode **23.9 Hz**, second 96 Hz (outside the band); modal mass 535 kg.
- A lasting 1 % drop in frequency is a 2 % loss of bending stiffness. The steel modulus alone moves the frequency by about 1 % between -20 and $+50$ °C, so temperature compensation is needed.
- **People change the frequency of a light footbridge.** One 75 kg walker at midspan lowers f_1 by 6.3 %; a crowd of one person per square meter lowers it by 22.7 %. On a road bridge with 20 t of modal mass one walker moves it by 0.19 %.

Measurement

- Bin width 0.0153 Hz; 17 averaged segments per record; sensor noise 2.8 μg in one bin. The mode's 0.48 Hz half-power bandwidth, not the bin width, limits precision.

- Simulated scatter of the hourly estimate from sensor noise: 0.053 % at 100 μg RMS of modal response with a curve fit, against 0.265 % with simple peak picking; a clear peak needs about 30 μg RMS. One walker gives about 29 mg RMS near midspan, so footfall is ample excitation.
- Because the walkers who excite the bridge also load it, the hourly estimate scatters by 0.45 % at 5 crossings an hour and by 0.23 % at 20. R2's 0.2 % is not met on the example bridge.
- Detecting a 1 % shift within 14 days with one false flag per year needs a daily residual of 0.75 % or less after temperature and load compensation.
- Strain: 1.65 μV per $\mu\epsilon$; 0.09 $\mu\epsilon$ RMS resolution at the assumed ADC noise; a 5 kN/m² crowd gives 106 $\mu\epsilon$ and one walker 3.2 $\mu\epsilon$, so strain is a usable load indicator.

Power, data and mounting

Quantity	Value
Power while recording, at the FieldNode port	92.9 mW
Average, with the rail off between records	16.9 mW (0.41 Wh per day; 17 % of FieldNode's 100 mW allowance)
Raw data	1.90 MB per hour; 1.39 GB per month; 22 months on 32 GB
Uplink	36 bytes hourly; 329 ms at SF9; fits EU868 at every rate, US915 and AS923 from SF9
Mass on the girder	3.34 kg (hub 0.87 kg, plate 1.35 kg, jack and clamps 1.12 kg); FieldNode core 2.41 kg
Mounting resonance of the hub	126 to 253 Hz (TRL 2 arrangement about 77 Hz)
Depth below the soffit	10 mm at most (limit 15 mm)

Cost

\$244.00 of BridgePulse-specific parts against the \$250 budget, which under BRP-DDR-001 D1 covers the BridgePulse-specific parts; with the FieldNode core (\$126.00, costed in its own repo) the complete monitor is \$370.00. The bridge, installation labor, access equipment, traffic management and paint testing are not included.

■ Key design choices

Each is adopted as recommended for TRL 3 under Amish's 2026-09-25 instruction, open for his review (BRP-DDR-001).

1. **Ambient vibration only.** No shaker or impact hammer; wind, footfall and traffic excite the bridge. Footfall is ample on a used footbridge; very quiet bridges remain a risk.
2. **Separate hub on the girder, FieldNode on a post.** The accelerometer must be on the structure, while the panel needs sun and the radio a clear view.
3. **Hourly 10 minute windows rather than continuous recording.** 16.9 mW against about 93 mW, with 24 frequency estimates a day.

4. **Temperature-compensated trend, not fixed limits.** A frequency band learned from the bridge's own baseline, with at least four weeks of data before any flag and a full year to cover seasons. BRP-CAL-001 shows it must model load on the deck as well as temperature.
5. **Foil gauge half-bridges with a dummy on a coupon.** Cheaper and easier to fit than weldable or vibrating-wire gauges, at the cost of long-term drift, to be checked early.
6. **One accelerometer at midspan.** Enough for the first vertical and torsional modes.
7. **Built on FieldNode, TwinKit and CityTwin.** The hub connects to one FieldNode M12 5-pin port, using its switched rail at 5 V and RS-485 on two signal pins. This follows FieldNode's candidate pinout; the pinout itself is still open (BRP-DDR-001, O1).
8. **Engineer-only alerts.** Flags go to the owner's engineer; the public CityTwin view shows only monitoring status.
9. **An RP2040 class microcontroller in the hub,** which post-processes each record from the card because the three axes do not fit in its RAM at once.

■ Safety

Safety: BridgePulse is a research prototype. It supports but never replaces inspection by qualified engineers, and a "no change" result never means a bridge is safe. Owners must not defer or skip inspections because a monitor is fitted.

Safety: Installation is work at height, often over water or traffic. Install only with the owner's written permission, with trained crews, fall protection, a rescue plan for work over water, and traffic management as local rules require. Never work alone.

Safety: Old steel bridges may be coated with lead or other hazardous paint. Test before removing any paint for strain gauges; if lead is present, use a trained contractor and local abatement rules. Gauge adhesives and coatings are chemicals: follow their safety data sheets, use gloves and eye protection and ventilate.

Safety: The FieldNode core contains a lithium iron phosphate cell. Use the fused, protected pack and cold-charge lockout specified by FieldNode and never mount a damaged pack.

Safety: Nothing may be drilled, welded or cut into the structure. The jack screw preload and the clamps must be checked so they cannot loosen and fall onto people, vehicles or boats below; use a secondary lanyard on the hub. Isolate the aluminium plate from the steel so galvanic corrosion cannot loosen it over time.

Safety: Fit tamper-resistant fasteners on the post-mounted FieldNode so the public cannot pull it off or hang from it, and keep cables out of reach from the deck.

■ Open questions

- [] 1. How can the frequency estimate be separated from the mass of people on a light footbridge: by gating out loaded segments, by regression on a load indicator, or only on heavier bridges? (BRP-CAL-001, B)
- [] 2. How much do frequencies move with temperature on small steel, concrete and timber bridges, and can a model trained on four weeks of data hold across seasons to a daily residual of 0.75 %?
- [] 3. What drift do foil strain gauges show outdoors over a year with the proposed coating?
- [] 4. Which FieldNode port pinout and protocol will be agreed (BRP-DDR-001, O1)?
- [] 5. What is the alert rule (size of shift, duration) and who receives it?

- [] 6. How are the temperature probes checked below -10°C , where the CalRig chamber does not reach?
- [] 7. Who owns the data, and what is published openly through CityTwin (BRP-DDR-001, O3)?